for the "learning loss" on account of closure of physical classrooms. 'With the huge digital divide and resource- and gadget-deficient families in India, we need more schools and higher education institutes on the ground than in the cyber-space,' read a statement by the Academics for Action and Development (AAD), a group of Delhi University teachers. Epidemiologist and public policy specialist Chandrakant Lahariya believes "setting up TV channels cannot undo the adverse impact of the past two years". Others claim that the government may have ensured delivery of content through these TV channels but it cannot stand in for a teacher to "actually teach" and respond to real-time queries even if education ministry officials maintain that experts conduct live interactive sessions on Skype on these channels.

The government's budgetary priorities do not inspire much hope either. Not only has budgetary allocation for PM e-Vidya been meagre since its inception, it has also seen a massive drop this year—from Rs 50 crore in 2021-22 to just Rs 0.1 crore this year. In fact, the budgetary allocation for the entire digital e-learning programme has gone down Rs 645.61 crore in the yesteryear to Rs 421 crore this year. There is no specific allocation for the digital university in the budget. Professor Tarun Jain of Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad has termed the investment "minuscule" against the tremendous learning loss. Sumeet Mehta, co-founder and CEO of LEAD School, also feels budgetary allocation should not promote virtual learning over physical schooling.

Not just online learning, budgetary support has lagged behind the reformist intent of the New Education Policy in 2020. On paper, there has been a 31 per cent hike in allocation to education in the past five years. But the actual expenditure has not increased much (see *Where is the Money for Education?*). In fact, budgetary allocation saw a drop in the very next year of the NEP's launch—from Rs 99,311.52 crore to Rs 93,224.31 crore. This year, the government has allocated Rs 1.04 lakh crore to education.

Top education ministry officials, speaking on condition of anonymity, admit that the government was aware of the need to hike the budgetary allocation, but blame the current low allocation to poor utilisation of funds by states. Education is a state subject and state governments implement the centrally-funded schemes. "Funds are allocated in the budget by considering past utilisation of funds," says an education ministry official. "Several states failed to utilise the funds sanctioned to them."

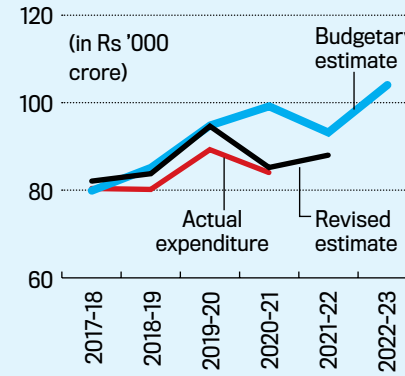
Amid a growing clamour for raising the allocation for education to 6 per cent of GDP from the current 2 per cent, the actual expenditure has been lower than the budgetary allocation since 2018-19. Several states have not even utilised the sanctioned funds. Depending on a state's requirement, the education ministry provides Rs 6.4 lakh for setting up an ICT lab and Rs 2.4 lakh for digital classroom. In 2021-22, of the Rs 956.8 crore sanctioned for digital classrooms, the states spent only Rs 9.8 crore. Barring Nagaland, Rajasthan and Sikkim, no state spent a single penny on digital classrooms. In their defence, the state governments claim that with schools shut during the pandemic, expenditure on digital or physical infrastructure came to a halt.

The blame game apart, both the central and state governments need to concentrate their energies on building a holistic model to help students learn and experience what they have missed in the two years sacrificed to the pandemic. As author and educationist Meeta Sengupta says, PM e-Vidya could be an education safety net offering a multilingual and multilocation supplementary learning system, but its success will depend on its inclusion and expanse. For that to happen, the Centre and the states must collaborate with not just enough funds but a plan for execution too. ■

—with **Shelly Anand**

WHERE IS THE MONEY FOR EDUCATION?

Despite a 31 per cent hike in budgetary allocation to education in the preceding five years, actual expenditure has not increased much



A SLOGAN WITHOUT ACTION

While the allocation to the government's e-learning programme has not seen any significant rise, actual expenditure dropped during the peak of the pandemic

